

Abu Dhabi: A visitor's guide



ghgt-15



جامعة خليفة
Khalifa University

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Abu Dhabi skyline from above



Whether you are planning a visit to Abu Dhabi or are already in the emirate, this section provides a host of useful information to help you make the most of your time here.

From the mini Arabic phrase book and currency converter to helpful hints and tips about visa regulations and what to do in an emergency, as well as insights into religion, culture and lifestyle, everything you need to know can be found within these pages.

Population

Abu Dhabi is the largest and most populated of the seven emirates that make up the United Arab Emirates, with over 80% of its landmass. The emirate's population, now over 1.6 million, is expected to reach 3 million by 2030. Across the UAE, Emirati citizens make up nearly 20% of the total population; the other 80% are expatriates from Asia, Africa, Australia, Europe and North America.

Local time

The UAE is four hours ahead of UTC (Co-ordinated Universal Time - formerly known as GMT) and there is no daylight saving. Hence, when it is 12.00 midday in Abu Dhabi, it is 3am in New York, 8am in London, 10 am in Johannesburg, 1.30pm in New Delhi, and 6pm in Sydney (not allowing for any summer time saving in those countries).

Social & business hours

Generally speaking, government departments, embassies and consulates work from 8am to 4pm. Embassies and consulates may designate specific times of day for processing certain requests (such as passport applications) so always call before you visit. The Islamic holy day is Friday and most organisations operate a Friday / Saturday weekend. Shops and visitor attractions are open on both days, though usually towards the end of the day or in the early evening on Fridays.

During the holy month of Ramadan shops often change their hours by closing during the day, re-opening an hour or two after sunset, and staying open later at night. Food outlets and restaurants generally remain closed or offer takeaway services only during the day and then open up for Iftar – the meal which breaks the fast - after sunset.

Safety

Abu Dhabi's virtually crime free environment and well organised emergency services will bring you peace of mind and a relaxing stay.

GETTING A VISA

Citizens of Australia, Andorra, Austria, Brunei, Belgium, Bulgaria, Canada, Croatia, Cyprus, Czech Republic, Denmark, Estonia, Finland, France, Germany, Greece, Hong Kong, Hungary, Iceland, Ireland, Italy, Japan, Latvia, Liechtenstein, Lithuania, Luxembourg, Malaysia, Malta, Monaco, The Netherlands, New Zealand, Norway, Poland, Portugal, Romania, San Marino, Singapore, Slovakia, Slovenia, South Korea, Spain, Sweden, Switzerland, United Kingdom, United States of America and the Vatican State can get a free-of-charge entry visa upon arrival at Abu Dhabi International Airport. GCC citizens do not need a visa to enter the UAE.

Citizens of all other countries will need to apply for a Tourist, Transit or Visit Visa prior to their trip. If you are flying with Etihad Airways, a visit visa may be arranged for you upon request. If you have booked your trip through a travel agency, in most cases they will be able to arrange this for you.

Five, four and three star hotels can apply for visas on behalf of guests who have booked a stay with them. Please note that not all five, four and three star hotels have this system in place. Make sure you check with your preferred hotel if they offer this service. This service does not currently apply to guests staying in hotel apartments. While the airline, travel agency and hotel can apply for your visa, please make sure you give yourself enough time for it to be approved, and note that they do not take responsibility if the visa is declined.

Otherwise, you will need to apply for a visa through your nearest UAE embassy. An eye scan will be required at the airport.

For more information on visa types or how to get your visa, visit the Abu Dhabi Government website or call its contact centre on +971 2 666 4442 (800-555 from inside the UAE)

IN AN EMERGENCY

The emergency phone number for Abu Dhabi Police is 999. Whether you need police assistance, an ambulance or for any other emergency 999 is the number to call and calls are free!

When calling 999, please remember to state your name, the nature of the accident, address of the emergency and how serious the situation is.

If you're involved in a traffic accident, it's important to contact the police immediately. In case of a minor incident, move your car to the road side, as there are fines for obstructing traffic. You cannot file an insurance claim without a police report.

For other enquiries, Abu Dhabi Police operates a dedicated Tourism Police section which will advise and guide you on a range of matters. You can contact them on +971 2 800 2626 and +971 2 512 7777, or visit www.adpolice.gov.ae

As per UAE federal law and Abu Dhabi Government law, all visitors to the UAE must have medical insurance cover. In case of emergency, treatment to stabilise the case is free. Other treatment must be covered by a cash payment or insurance card for covered individuals.

In a medical emergency, Abu Dhabi's Sheikh Khalifa Medical City (+971 2 610 2000) and Al Noor Hospital (+971 2 626 5265) both have Accident and Emergency units. If you're injured in a traffic accident, you will automatically be taken to Sheikh Khalifa Medical City, as it has the best A&E treatment facilities.

The Abu Dhabi Government portal (www.abudhabi.ae) provides an updated list of 24-hour pharmacies and medical services, including hospitals, clinics, and medical centres. If you don't have internet access you can call the toll free number 800 555 (+971 2 666 4442).



WOMEN & CHILDREN

Women should face no problems while travelling in the UAE. The police are helpful and respectful; call them at any time if you face any unwanted attention. It is courteous to dress with a little modesty, particularly in outlying areas where people tend to be more conservative.

Abu Dhabi is a safe and entertaining place for children of all ages. There are plenty of parks, some great sandy beaches, and kids zones and crèche facilities in all major shopping malls. The majority of hotels cater well for children and offer everything from babysitting services to child friendly activities and children's swimming pools. Restaurants vary; some welcome children more than others.

CLIMATE & WHAT TO WEAR

This is a destination with almost year-round sunshine, little rainfall and near perfect winter temperatures.

Abu Dhabi has a sub-tropical, arid climate. Sunny blue skies and high temperatures can be expected most of the year. Rainfall is sporadic, falling mainly in winter (November to March) and averaging 12 cms per year in most of the emirate. Rain is more common in the 'Oasis City' of Al Ain, the emirate's second largest city, due to its proximity to the Hajar mountains.

Temperatures range from a low of around 13C (50F) on a winter's night, to a high of around 42C (118F) on a summer's day. The cooler months, November to April, are the most pleasant time to visit, when temperatures are around 24C (75F) during the day and 13C (56F) at night.



What to wear

Lightweight summer clothing is suitable for most of the year, but something slightly warmer may be needed for the winter months. Be sure to take some sort of jacket or sweater when visiting hotels or the cinema, as the air conditioning can be fierce.

Although the attitude towards dress is fairly liberal throughout the Emirates, a healthy amount of respect for local customs doesn't go amiss, especially when shopping or sightseeing. Short or tight clothing may be worn, but it will attract attention - most of it unwelcome.

Malls, health clubs and resort facilities are generally more accepting of what's fashionable, but when visiting government offices it is best to cover your shoulders and legs. It is especially recommended that you dress more conservatively during Ramadan.

In the evenings, restaurants and clubs usually have a mix of western, Arabic and Asian styles. Again, ladies are advised to take a pashmina or jacket because of cold air conditioning.



CULTURE & LIFESTYLE

The combination of international influences and a strong commitment to local heritage has created an intriguing mix of new and old.

Abu Dhabi's culture is firmly rooted in Arabia's Islamic traditions. Islam is more than a religion; it is a way of life that governs everyday events from what to wear to what to eat and drink. The UAE's culture and heritage is inextricably linked to its religion, and it is a shining example of Islam's true commitment to tolerance and hospitality.

Foreigners are free to practice their own religion and the dress code is liberal. Women are able to drive and walk around unescorted. Among the most highly prized virtues are courtesy and hospitality, and visitors are sure to be charmed by the genuine friendliness of the people. Despite the speed of economic

development over the last 30 years, Abu Dhabi continues to promote traditional cultural and sporting events, such as falconry, camel racing and traditional dhow sailing.

National dress

UAE nationals usually wear traditional dress in public. For men, this is the kandura - a white full length shirt-like garment, which is worn with a white or red checkered headdress, known as a ghutra. This is secured with a black cord (agal).

Sheikhs and important businessmen may also wear a thin, gold-trimmed robe (bisht) over their kandura at important events.

In public, women wear a long, loose black robe (abaya) that covers their normal clothes - plus a headscarf (sheyla). The abaya is often of very sheer, flowing fabric with intricate embroidery and beadwork along the wrists and hemline. Sheylas are also becoming more elaborate and a statement of individuality, particularly among the young. Headwear varies with some women wearing a thin black veil covering their face and others, generally older women, wearing a leather veil (burka), which covers the nose, brow, cheekbones and lips.

Photography

While normal tourist photography is acceptable, it is polite to ask permission before taking photos of people, particularly women. Photographs of government buildings, military installations and ports and airports should not be taken. Also, cameras may be banned in public areas designated for women and children only.

FOOD & CUISINE

Abu Dhabi has numerous dining options and visitors are often bewildered by the sheer volume and [diversity of choice](#) across the emirate. Cuisine from around the world mingles in Abu Dhabi with restaurants offering a vibrant and varied mix of international flavours and impressive culinary standards.

[Hotel outlets](#) serve alcohol and these are complemented by many superb unlicensed outlets across the emirate. Non-Muslims can consume pork in certain restaurants – any dishes using pork ingredients will be prepared separately from non-pork dishes and are clearly marked on the menu.





RELIGION & RAMADAN

Islam is the official religion of the UAE, and is widely practiced. The Islamic holy day is Friday and there are five pillars of Islam, which all Muslims must follow: the Profession of Faith, Prayer, Charity, Fasting, and the Pilgrimage to Makkah. Additionally, a Muslim is required to pray (facing Makkah) five times a day. The times vary according to the position of the sun, when the modern-day call to prayer is transmitted through loudspeakers on mosque minarets.

The UAE Constitution provides for freedom of religion in accordance with established customs. Abu Dhabi is tolerant of other religions with people being free to practice their religious beliefs, so long as they do not interfere with Islam. Non-Muslims can get an insight into Islam through complimentary guided tours of [the spectacular Sheikh Zayed Grand Mosque](#) - one of the world's largest. The tours run at different times during the week.



Ramadan

Ramadan is the holy month in which Muslims commemorate the revelation of the Holy Quran (Islam's holy book). It's a time of fasting and Muslims abstain from all food, drink, smoking and unclean thoughts (or activities) between dawn and dusk. At sunset, the fast is broken with the Iftar feast, the timings of which are published in all daily newspapers.

All over the city, festive Ramadan tents are filled to the brim each evening with people of all nationalities and religions enjoying traditional Arabic mezze and sweets. The dates of Ramadan change each year following the Islamic lunar calendar.

During the holy month of Ramadan, shops often change their hours by closing during the day, re-opening an hour or two after sunset, and staying open later at night. Food outlets and restaurants generally remain closed or offer takeaway services only during the day and then open up for Iftar after sunset.

Non-Muslims are respectfully required to refrain from eating, drinking or smoking in public places during daylight hours. Failure to do so could upset people or lead to an official complaint. During Ramadan, shops and parks usually open and close later. In addition, no live music or dancing is allowed (so nightclubs tend to close for the entire month) and cinemas limit daytime screenings.

Ramadan ends with a three-day celebration and holiday called Eid Al Fitr, which is characterized by gifts being given amongst families, friends, neighbours and charities.



MONEY

Currency

The local currency is the UAE dirham (AED or Dhs) which is divided into 100 fils and is pegged against the US \$ (US\$ 1: AED 3.6725).

Credit and debit cards are widely accepted. Foreign currencies and travellers' cheques can be exchanged in licenced exchange offices, banks and hotels, a passport is required. Personal cheques can be a bit trickier and many places won't accept them. If you're shopping in the souks (markets) or in smaller shops, cash is the best option.

Banks

A well structured and expansive network of local and international banks, strictly controlled by the UAE Central Bank, offers a full range of commercial and personal services. Transfers can be made easily as there is no exchange control and the dirham is freely convertible. Banking hours are generally Saturday to Thursday, 8am - 1pm (some banks also keep later hours). Some banks have small branches based in malls, which are open in the evening.

ATMs

Most banks operate ATMs, which accept a range of cards. Most ATMs, although linked to a specific bank, are part of a central network so you can transact with a bank card for a nominal charge. Common systems accepted around Abu Dhabi include American Express, Cirrus, Global Access, MasterCard, Plus System and VISA. ATMs can be found in all shopping malls, major supermarkets, most petrol stations and the airport. For international cards, the exchange rates used in transactions are normally competitive and the process is faster and far less hassle than using traditional travellers' cheques.

Money exchange

'Bureau de Change' offices are all over Abu Dhabi and offer rates often better than the banks. You'll find them in all major malls and popular shopping districts. They are usually open Saturday to Thursday, from 8am - 1pm and 4.30pm to 8.30pm, and on Friday evenings. Many hotels will also exchange money and travellers' cheques at standard (non-competitive) rates.

VISITOR INFORMATION CENTRES

There are a number of visitor services centres around the emirate which act as one-stop shops for destination information and assistance.

Abu Dhabi International Airport

Daily, 7am - 1am

Ferrari World Abu Dhabi

Daily, except Mondays, 11am – 8pm

World Trade Center Souk

Daily, 10am – 8pm



TAXES, SERVICE CHARGES & TIPPING



Tipping is not expected, but is commonly practised in the emirate. Gratuities to hotel and restaurant staff are at your discretion. Many fine dining and high-end restaurants may add a service charge (usually around 10%) and a tourism levy of 6% to your bill. These charges are often included in the menu prices and the menu will denote when they are.

If you are very happy with the service, it is not expected but quite common to leave a tip on top of the already included (16%) fees & service charges. If these charges are not included, then you may like to add a 10-15% tip to the total bill.



15th International Conference on Greenhouse Gas Control Technologies

Abu Dhabi National Exhibition Centre
(ADNEC), Abu Dhabi,
United Arab Emirates

5-8 October 2020



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